

Discovering yourself

Inside view

Conversation 1

Janet Hi, it's me again, Janet Li. I'm still a student at the University of Oxford in England. But I'm not in Oxford right now. And I haven't gone back home to China either. It's the long vacation now, and believe it or not, it's the middle of summer. I'm spending my summer in one of the world's greatest cities. I'm in London, home to the Houses of Parliament, Big Ben, Tower Bridge ... and the double-decker bus. I want to find out what it's like to live in this busy, lively city. So I'm working for London Time Off, a website about what's on in London. This is Joe ... he's my boss, and this is Andy, who is a reporter. And what's my job? Well, I don't know yet, because it's my first day. But I'm meant to be shadowing Andy. Oh, what I mean is, I'm going to be helping him. So can you tell me something about London, Andy?

Andy It's the greatest city in the world.

Joe Except for New York!

Andy New York? Don't make me laugh!

Joe And your point is ...?

Andy Look, if you want my opinion, London is greater than New York ...

Joe No, I don't want your opinion, thank you very much. It's a fact.

Andy A fact! Are you serious?

Janet And here we are in London, probably the greatest city in the world.

Andy What? Probably? Excuse me, I prefer to deal with this myself ...

Joe Ah, dream on, Andy ...

Conversation 2

Janet So when did you start working at London Time Off?

Andy About a year ago.

Janet And I hope you don't mind my asking, but do you like working here?

Andy Yes, I love it. I mean, Joe and I get along quite well. He drives me crazy sometimes, because he's my boss, and I wish I earned a bit more money, but ... I think my job is really cool, because I get to see everything that's happening in London. And I didn't want to join the rat race.

Janet What do you mean by the rat race?

Andy You know, doing the same thing day in, day out, and not doing anything creative, or having any time to enjoy life. It's the last thing I want to do.

Janet So do you mind telling me what you do exactly?

Andy Basically, we check out new events on the London music scene, you know, new clubs, the latest plays and films, as well as exhibitions in galleries and museums. Then we go and film interviews with the musicians or the actors, or anyone who has anything to do with the event.

- Janet** OK, then what happens?
- Andy** We edit the interviews, and then we upload it all onto the website. We get 200,000 hits a week. We're London's biggest listings site.
- Janet** Can I ask you something else?
- Andy** Fire away.
- Janet** What are we going to do now?
- Andy** I need to go back to my flat, and get my research. Then we've got an interview to do. Let's get the tube back to my place.
- Janet** And what about Joe?
- Andy** Well, he's supposed to be on his way to the National Theatre, to do an interview with the director of a new play. But I kind of hope he gets lost on the way. Then he'll discover what a great place London is.
- Janet** I don't understand.
- Andy** I'm joking! Come on, let's go!

Outside view

Part 1

- Presenter** Happiness is not what most students have in mind when they think of school. Yet a school in Germany has developed a novel way to raise the morale of its students, by teaching happiness in classes. Students at Heidelberg's Willy Hellpach School of Economics are learning how to achieve happiness as an official subject, alongside mathematics and languages. This is the first school in Germany to develop a happiness course, intended for 17- to 19-year-olds preparing for university entrance exams. Ernst Fritz-Schubert, the school's principal, is on a mission to change things.
- Ernst** It was my idea – I've been at this school for 31 years, and I feel that school and happiness have to be reunited. These are two terms which are not considered together, because one does not connect school with happiness. In

some cases school comes behind the dentist on the popularity scale and we should try to push schools' popularity a bit. It has been proved by science that a happy student can learn more than an unhappy one. Unhappy students can concentrate for a while but do not use all their potential. The happiness classes are intended to help students fulfil their potential. They will help the students live happy and prosperous lives.

- Presenter** The classes aim to help students in achieving a positive state of mind, by using all their own resources and boosting their self-esteem. In addition, they hope classes will increase self-awareness and physical comfort. Happiness classes are also intended to make students more aware about their environment and society as a whole. During classes students are encouraged to express themselves and observe their peers' behaviour. The classes are taught by Bjoern Bonn, an actor and visiting lecturer.

Part 2

- Bjoern** One of the exercises I do is to have one of the students walk across the classroom, with the others copying his walk. Through this exercise, I hope they learn something about themselves. Why do I move like this? How do others see my way of walking? I hope that with a higher body awareness they ideally – of course it will take time – achieve a higher self-consciousness which could lead to happiness.
- Wolfgang** We give these classes to students to help them find happiness. Now the question is: How do I define happiness? Happiness is for example a strengthening of the personality. We are providing helpful suggestions to make stronger people. People that ask "Who am I as a person? Am I really happy?"

Pascal

It takes time and everybody has to find happiness for themselves. You cannot go into a coaching lesson and say, "Teach me happiness." One can only get indications from teachers or the visiting lecturers. There are also happiness scientists, if we could talk to one of those I'm sure he would have some hints.

Yosma

You would think that the teachers are writing definitions on the board. Not true. Those who want happiness have to find it for themselves, you cannot really learn that.

Presenter

So what does it take to be happy, and can you learn it at school?

Listening in News report

Recent statistics show that young people are heading abroad in ever-increasing numbers – at least temporarily. Experts say spending time overseas can give students an advantage when looking for a job after they graduate. Employers are attracted to candidates with international experience and global skills.

Audrey Morgan, a graduate of the University of Pennsylvania, was inspired to learn Spanish. She decided to spend a semester studying in Spain during her junior year. That experience led to the job she has today, as an engineer for a technology company with offices all over the world.

Her current work project involves working closely with an organization in Spain, and her fluent Spanish means she is able to translate documents from Spanish to English and communicate with her Spanish co-workers. She hopes to work in one of her company's international offices within a few years.

It's up to students to decide how long they want to spend studying overseas. They may go for a year, a semester or a summer. However long or short the time, they are sure to have a rewarding experience.

- 1 How does studying abroad give students an advantage in the job hunt?
- 2 How much time should students spend overseas?

Passage 1

Interviewer

Can you tell me ... how do you think you have changed as you have matured? What things have had a major influence on you?

Speaker 1

Well, let me think ... I suppose going to university had a big impact on my life. It made me much more open-minded. I met so many different types of people there with weird and wonderful ideas and it changed the way I see the world. I'm much more tolerant now ... It made me a more rounded person.

Interviewer

Great ... And has any particular person had a central role in forming your character?

Speaker 1

I guess that'd have to be my grandfather. I was very close to him and he taught me to stand up for my beliefs. He was always telling me about his ...

Interviewer

So what people or events have had an impact on your life?

Speaker 2

I think that travelling in my gap year made me grow up and see both the beauty of the world and, well ... just the generosity of ordinary people. I travelled a lot around Asia and you know, I found that in some of the poorest countries, like Cambodia and Laos, people share whatever little they have, and they possess a real joy for life. It's probably made me a less selfish person.

Interviewer

Interesting. ... So you would recommend that young people take a gap year to discover themselves and the world?

Speaker 2

Definitely. It gives you an opportunity to learn about the world

Interviewer beyond the one you grew up in and I found it really ...

Interviewer Could you tell me what things in your life have had the greatest influence in forming your personality?

Speaker 3 Well ... a couple of years ago I was on a reality TV show where a group of young people all lived in a house together. Each week someone was voted off by the audience. I got down to the final three! I suppose being on the show and seeing how the other contestants behaved made me realize how selfish and spiteful some people can be just to get what they want. I also realized it's best to just be yourself in life. If you pretend to be someone different people will eventually see through the lies.

Interviewer Right ... And how did you feel when you were eventually voted off?

Speaker 3 Relieved, to be honest with you. But you know ... a slight regret that I didn't win because I kind of ...

Interviewer So can you tell me, what one thing do you think has had the biggest impact on your life?

Speaker 4 Hmm, that's a difficult question. But I think helping victims of the tsunami in 2004 had a very great impact on me. I'm half Thai and I'd just arrived in Thailand for a family Christmas holiday. When I heard the news I knew I had to help – you couldn't not. I ended up acting as an interpreter for a group of volunteer doctors. It was an incredibly difficult time but you know, even in the middle of such a horrific tragedy there is still a huge amount of genuine human kindness.

Interviewer That's amazing! And has it changed the way you view your future ...

is Joan Robinson, an academic counsellor at Manchester University. She gives advice to school students on choosing the right subject to study at university. Joan, welcome to the show.

Joan Thanks Tony.

Tony So Joan, what do our listeners need to think about when choosing a course? It's a huge, potentially life-changing decision, isn't it?

Joan Yes. I generally give students advice in two areas. Firstly, know yourself, and secondly, think to the future.

Tony When you say "know yourself" what do you mean?

Joan Basically, I mean evaluate your own personal strengths and weaknesses, your personality traits and the things you like.

Tony I see ... So how can our listeners do this?

Joan Well, start by asking yourself questions to help reflect on your life so far. For example, what subjects are you good at? Are you an organized and self-disciplined person? Are you confident and outgoing? Do you like working with others in a team or do you prefer working alone? These kinds of questions will help you discover more about yourself.

Tony Sounds like good advice. How about your second point regarding the future?

Joan Well, your choice of major subject is likely to have a significant impact on your future career so it's important to look into this carefully. I recommend you check not only which academic subjects will help you get into a particular area of work, but also look carefully at what universities offer. Each university has its strengths so try to choose one that is the best in your chosen field. Find out what links the department has to related industries and leading companies in it.

Tony Good point. Now I'd like to take some calls from our listeners. First up we have James on the line. Hi James! How can we help?

James Hi. I'm interested in a career in IT and I'd like to ask Joan whether she thinks it's better to go to a highly respected university, like Oxford, or to study somewhere that has more of a vocational focus?

Passage 2

Tony Talking to us today in our *Life Choices* series

Joan Well, James, you know it really depends on what you expect to get out of a university and how you see your future. Basically a handful of the brightest graduates are picked from the top universities around the world to join the leading IT companies. So I'd say if you're a high-flyer then this is the route that might be for you. But if you are looking for a more mainstream career then you should consider a course that helps you acquire practical, transferable skills that you can use in the workplace ... and look at which universities have the best levels of graduate recruitment for the kind of job you are aiming for.

James I see! Thanks a lot. That really helps me out ...

Inside view

Conversation 1

- Janet** Hey, look at that! It's just like I've seen it in the films!
- Andy** Welcome to London, my home town. We're in Southwark, south of the river. There's London Bridge off to your left, and there's Tower Bridge.
- Janet** I'm really impressed. How old is it?
- Andy** It's only about 120 years old.
- Janet** Well, that's quite old.
- Andy** The London Docks used to be around this area. What happened was that about three or four times a day, they raised Tower Bridge, so the bigger ships could come right into London. But because they couldn't go under London Bridge, they had to stop and unload here.
- Janet** Does Tower Bridge still open?
- Andy** Well, not so often. When I was a kid I think I saw Tower Bridge go up fairly often – all the traffic had to wait for the ships to pass through the bridge. Anyway, just this side of London Bridge were lots of warehouses, where they kept their cargo. But during the Second World War there was lots of bombing over London ...
- Janet** Yes, I read about that ... the Blitz?
- Andy** That's right. And even when I was a kid, I remember that many of the buildings were still damaged. But in the late 1980s and '90s

this whole area was redeveloped – you can see for yourself, it's a trendy place to live now.

- Janet** Is the River Thames still polluted?
- Andy** Well, it certainly used to be polluted. I remember it had a very distinctive smell. If you fell in, they used to take you to hospital.
- Janet** That sounds revolting!
- Andy** Yes, but in the 1960s they cleaned it up, and in fact it's now one of the cleanest city rivers in the world.

Conversation 2

- Janet** It's very different from the parts of London I know.
- Andy** The thing about Southwark is that it's a typical suburb of London, full of old buildings and shops. And this is where I grew up. I used to live in that building there.
- Janet** It's amazing. It looks very old.
- Andy** Yes, it's about 80 years old.
- Janet** And where did you go to school?
- Andy** Let me see. Yes, it was about a mile away from here. From about the age of eight, I used to go by bike. We all made our way to school on our own, meeting up with friends along the way until there was a large gang of us kids as we got closer to school. These days parents are much more protective and take their kids to school by car. It's safer, but it's not as much fun. Anyway, where was I?
- Janet** You were telling me about your schooldays.

Andy That's right. Anyway, I stayed at school until I was 16, and then I went to a college of further education, and did my A levels. And after that, I decided to go to university.

Janet Your parents must have been proud of you.

Andy Yes, I think so. I was the first person in my family to go to uni.

Janet That's fascinating.

Andy And what about you?

Janet Oh, it was a typical childhood in Anshan, nothing much to tell.

Andy But I have no idea what a typical childhood is like in China.

Janet OK, I'll tell you. Let me think ...

Andy Oh, hang on! Do you mind waiting here for a minute? Let me go up to my flat and get my research, and then you can tell me about it while we're on our way back to the studio.

Janet OK.

Andy Back in a minute ...

team travels on horseback to bring medicine to a remote mountain village. And UNICEF is helping the children get an education.

Dr Laroche During the time of Taliban we have made a survey among 40,000 kids. And, uh, and they all say that the first thing they want is peace. And the second thing that they want is, was education.

Presenter The Taliban destroyed almost 2,000 schools. Under the Taliban, girls were not allowed to attend school at all.

Moyeen Well, over 50 per cent of the school has been destroyed completely. In the rest of the 50 per cent schools which, eh, eh, needs repair, we are trying to accommodate all the children in the schools.

Presenter Some of the schools are in people's homes. This is a home school in Kabul. The teacher, Habiba Kilwati, has been running the school for 12 years. She supervises 26 other schools like it.

Outside view

Part 1

Presenter Around the world many children are living in poverty. Many children live in countries where there is war. Many children do not get enough to eat. Some of these children are suffering from malnutrition. Many children in the world cannot go to school. One agency that is helping these children is UNICEF. UNICEF means the United Nations Children's Fund. UNICEF has more than 7,000 people working in 157 countries around the world to help children. One country where they are doing a great deal of work is Afghanistan. A whole generation of children in Afghanistan has never known peace, until recently. Now, UNICEF is bringing food for malnourished children. They are bringing medicine. Here a medical

Part 2

Student 1 We want to learn, so we can become teachers, doctors, or engineers and be like normal students.

Presenter It was dangerous for children to go to school. Under the Taliban, police punished families whose children went to school. Today, children are happy to be in school.

Student 2 This morning I had some tea and an egg and came to school. I have notebooks, pencils, erasers, and friends and fun here.

Presenter UNICEF is helping rebuild the educational system in Afghanistan in many ways. UNICEF is helping to train teachers. They are rebuilding schools. They are printing textbooks, and delivering books and other supplies to schools. This girls school was closed under the Taliban. Now it is opening again. It has room for

Student 3

960 students. These girls are happy to be back in school.

I am very disappointed and sad that I wasted six years. There was no education then. I tried to study then with my parents, but it's not the same. It wasn't so bad, but now I am much happier because the schools are reopening.

Maliha

We plan to open the schools and get these children enrolled and back in school. And to give them back their education, so they can read and write.

Afghan man

When the Taliban came to power and closed the schools, girls stayed at home. Now there is an opportunity for them to continue their education. We are very happy about this. We can be proud of our girls, our young people. They can go back to school.

Presenter

UNICEF is working on its mission to bring food, medicine, and education to the children of Afghanistan. In the process, they are also bringing hope.

the girls when they were younger, sitting under a tree holding their beloved dog. The result is a heartwarming image that shows how much they have all grown – and how the sisters' love for Tigger has never changed.

- 1 Why do people recreate their childhood photos according to the news report?
- 2 Why did the Dobbie sisters recreate the photo?

Passage 1

One of the strangest feelings I've ever had was when I returned by chance to a place where I'd been happy as a child. My husband and I were visiting some friends for the weekend – they lived about 200 kilometres away. We were driving along when I suddenly saw a church in the distance that I recognized. My favourite aunt had lived very near it on a farm that my brother and I used to visit once a year with our parents.

We were city kids, brought up in the middle of London, and this was a working farm – the real thing – with cows in cowsheds, fields with ponds and a muddy yard full of smelly pigs, and – we had the run of the whole place – it was just paradise for us.

And then – there was the food – oh, home-made jam and bread and cakes, milk fresh from the cow. And my aunt Lottie – a farmer's wife – and her husband, Uncle George and their kids, Katie and Ben, our two cousins who my brother and I really got on with. It was heaven that week we used to spend there. They moved from the farm when I was ... how old? – about 14. So I'd never been back or seen it again.

Anyway, there we were, and I'd just seen the church – so we turned off and drove down this really narrow lane. And before I knew it we were in front of Aunt Lottie's farm! The extraordinary thing was that it hadn't changed – not one tiny bit.

It was a lovely old place with a typical country cottage garden, full of flowers. There were lots of barns and sheds – they were next to – next to the farm. And you know, I can't even begin to describe the feeling I had standing there. It was – oh, what was it? – an incredibly powerful feeling of longing – nostalgia for the past – for times when I'd been very, very happy. But it was the past. I hadn't been

Listening in

News report

For those of you who were thinking the selfie was the final development in photography, there's something new – a growing trend for people to recreate their childhood photos as adults. Some people recreate the photos as an amusing gift for their family, and others do it to relive their happy memories. Some of the photos have spread quickly across social media after being shared online.

The Dobbie sisters' family photos are the latest to go viral. The four sisters from Australia decided to create one last memory with their pet dog just before his death. They'd had Tigger since they were all children, but after 16 years together, they made the difficult decision to put him to rest. They decided to recreate a photo they found showing

there for 20 years and I couldn't go back, so I also had a feeling of huge sadness, that I couldn't have those times again. And – at the same time – great sweetness, because those times had been so happy, so innocent – because I was a child! So there was this extraordinary mix – of longing, sadness and sweetness, all at the same time. It was the strangest feeling I've ever had.

Passage 2

Interviewer So what's your first memory of school, Kevin?

Kevin I was really looking forward to school, I remember that, I just couldn't wait. Yeah, Johnny, my brother, was a year older than me and he seemed so grown-up, with his red blazer and smart shoes. And I wanted to go to school and be grown-up too. I don't remember much of the first day actually, apart from this little boy lying on the floor and screaming and screaming and me thinking what a baby he was.

Interviewer Right! What about you, Eva?

Eva I just have this one memory of this coat rack with all our coats. And I was looking for my peg which had a little picture of an elephant next to it. I remember I was crying because I wanted to go home and I couldn't get my coat on. I was crying so much and then the teacher came and helped me.

Interviewer OK, so what about your first best friend at school?

Kevin Oh, yeah, well, Steve, I remember him, because he's still my best friend!

Interviewer Still your best friend!

Eva That's so great!

Kevin Yeah, we didn't know each other before we started school but we became really good friends and so did our mums. Our families ended up going on holiday together and that kind of thing. But we used to fight a lot, Steve and I, and the

teachers used to get very cross with us. But we were just having fun.

Interviewer
Eva

Cool! And what about you, Eva?

My best friend was a girl called Robina. She had short blond hair, I remember I thought she looks (looked) like an angel. We sat next to each other and held hands and played fairies in the playground. She left in Year 3 and I cried for days.

Interviewer

Oh, how sad! So what about the day you left school? How was that?

Eva

I had a lot of mixed feelings, I remember walking home with this amazing feeling of freedom, you know, no more rules, no more bossy teachers. But I also felt pretty sad, because I'd had some good times. I was in a group of girls who were so supportive of each other.

Kevin

I couldn't wait to leave, I was counting the days. I just wanted to get a job, get a life, earn some cash. The day I left, I went out to celebrate with a couple of my mates and – had a very good time!